

TEXAS DEPARTMENT OF STATE HEALTH SERVICES

CENTER FOR HEALTH STATISTICS (CHS)

STANDARD OPERATING PROCEDURE (SOP)

Measles Outbreak Response Operations

Document Information

Item	Details
SOP Title	Measles Outbreak Response Operations
Department	Center for Health Statistics (CHS)
Version	1.0
Prepared By	Naomi Agwunobi, Health Informatics Officer & SOP Developer / Project Coordinator
Prepared By	Gabrielle Beckham, Health Informatics Officer & SOP Developer / Project Coordinator
Approved By	Tarik Brown, Director, Center for Health Statistics

1. Executive Summary

The Texas Department of State Health Services (DSHS) Center for Health Statistics (CHS) supports public health emergency response efforts by providing data management, reporting, operational support, and workforce resources during disease outbreaks. During the statewide measles outbreak response, CHS personnel were assigned to support outbreak-related activities, including data reporting, surveillance support, communication coordination, and collaboration with epidemiology teams.

To better understand staff experiences and identify opportunities for improvement, CHS conducted a workforce assessment involving approximately 25–30 employees who participated in outbreak response activities. Survey results indicated several strengths, including supportive leadership, effective telework operations, and successful onboarding processes. However, staff also identified challenges related to communication consistency, training availability, assignment clarity, workload management, and overtime expectations.

Key findings included:

- Training was helpful but lacked regular refresher sessions.
- Standard Operating Procedures were not always readily available.
- Communication between CHS and epidemiology teams was occasionally inconsistent.
- Staff desired clearer expectations regarding assignment duration and role responsibilities.
- Employees experienced periods of high workload volume and burnout.
- Telework arrangements improved productivity and employee satisfaction.
- Leadership was viewed as supportive and responsive throughout the response effort.

This Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) was developed to address those findings by establishing standardized workflows, communication pathways, onboarding procedures, reporting requirements, training expectations, and employee wellness practices. The goal of this SOP is to promote consistency, improve efficiency, strengthen communication, and support successful outbreak response operations.

2. Purpose

The purpose of this SOP is to provide a standardized framework for managing measles outbreak response operations within the Center for Health Statistics.

Specifically, this SOP seeks to:

- Improve communication and coordination across response teams.
 - Establish consistent operational workflows.
 - Promote accurate and timely reporting practices.
 - Define staff responsibilities and expectations.
 - Support employee preparedness and professional development.
 - Reduce operational disruptions and inefficiencies.
 - Promote employee wellness and workforce sustainability during prolonged response periods.
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3. Scope

This SOP applies to all CHS personnel assigned to outbreak response activities, including:

- Full-time employees.
- Temporary reassigned personnel.
- Remote and teleworking employees.
- Team Leads and Supervisors.
- CHS Leadership.
- Personnel supporting statewide epidemiological response operations.

The procedures outlined in this document shall be followed throughout the duration of outbreak response assignments.

4. Background

Measles is a highly contagious viral disease that requires rapid public health intervention to prevent widespread transmission. Effective outbreak response depends on accurate data collection, timely reporting, coordinated communication, and efficient workforce management.

The statewide measles response required CHS staff to assume additional responsibilities beyond their routine duties. These responsibilities included processing surveillance data, generating reports, supporting epidemiological investigations, coordinating communications, and assisting with outbreak-related operational tasks.

During the response period, staff experienced changing priorities, increased workloads, and evolving operational requirements. As a result, opportunities were identified to improve training, communication, workflow standardization, and employee support.

This SOP incorporates lessons learned from the outbreak response and provides guidance for future public health emergencies.

5. Roles and Responsibilities

5.1 CHS Staff

CHS staff are responsible for:

- Completing assigned outbreak response duties.
- Following established workflows and reporting procedures.
- Participating in required training and refresher sessions.
- Maintaining accurate documentation of completed work.
- Escalating issues through established communication channels.
- Protecting confidential information and complying with data security requirements.
- Supporting continuity of operations through effective handoff documentation.

5.2 Team Leads

Team Leads are responsible for:

- Assigning daily operational tasks.
- Monitoring workload distribution.
- Conducting daily team briefings.
- Addressing operational concerns.
- Facilitating communication between staff and leadership.
- Ensuring compliance with SOP requirements.

5.3 CHS Leadership

CHS Leadership shall:

- Provide strategic direction.
- Establish operational priorities.

- Communicate assignment expectations.
- Monitor employee well-being.
- Coordinate staffing resources.
- Facilitate communication with external response partners.
- Review operational performance metrics.

5.4 Outbreak Response Personnel

Personnel assigned to outbreak response operations shall:

- Follow established reporting schedules.
 - Complete assigned training requirements.
 - Participate in scheduled meetings and briefings.
 - Maintain situational awareness of outbreak developments.
 - Support response activities as directed by leadership.
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6. Workflow Management

6.1 Onboarding Workflow

To ensure consistent onboarding of response personnel, the following process shall be followed:

Step 1: Assignment Notification

Employees shall receive official notification from leadership regarding outbreak response assignments.

Step 2: Training Completion

Employees shall complete all required training modules prior to assuming independent responsibilities.

Step 3: SOP Distribution

Employees shall receive access to all relevant SOPs, workflow documents, and reporting resources.

Step 4: System Access

Required access to Teams, SharePoint, reporting systems, and data repositories shall be granted.

Step 5: Shadowing and Knowledge Transfer

Whenever possible, employees shall shadow experienced personnel prior to independent work assignments.

Step 6: Independent Operations

Employees shall begin assigned duties following completion of onboarding requirements.

6.2 Daily Operations Workflow

The standard daily workflow includes:

- Morning briefing.
 - Review of priorities and assignments.
 - Data collection and validation.
 - Report preparation.
 - Communication with designated contacts.
 - Escalation of issues as needed.
 - End-of-day status documentation.
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7. Communication Protocol

Effective communication is essential to outbreak response operations.

Internal Communication

Communication shall occur through approved platforms including Microsoft Teams, SharePoint, and official email channels.

Daily operational updates shall be communicated by Team Leads.

Weekly leadership meetings shall be conducted to review response activities and address operational concerns.

Escalation Process

Staff Member → Team Lead → CHS Leadership → Appropriate Response Leadership

Communication Expectations

All communications should be:

- Timely
- Professional
- Accurate
- Consistent
- Action-oriented

Role changes, assignment updates, and reporting expectations shall be communicated as soon as possible to affected personnel.

8. Training and Preparedness Standards

Training shall include:

- Measles outbreak fundamentals.
- Public health surveillance processes.
- Data quality and validation procedures.
- Reporting workflows.
- Communication protocols.
- Information security requirements.

Refresher training sessions should be provided every two weeks during active response periods.

All training completion records shall be maintained by leadership.

9. Employee Wellness and Burnout Prevention

Maintaining employee well-being is critical during extended response operations.

Leadership should monitor indicators of burnout, including:

- Increased absenteeism.
- Reduced productivity.
- Employee fatigue.
- Elevated stress levels.

Strategies to reduce burnout include:

- Rotating assignments.
 - Providing telework flexibility.
 - Encouraging regular breaks.
 - Monitoring overtime utilization.
 - Conducting wellness check-ins.
 - Recognizing employee contributions.
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10. Telework and Hybrid Operations

Survey results indicated that telework contributed positively to productivity and employee satisfaction.

When operationally feasible, telework should remain the preferred work arrangement for outbreak response personnel.

Employees working remotely must:

- Maintain access to approved systems.
- Protect confidential information.
- Participate in required meetings.

- Remain available during designated work hours.

Return-to-office requirements should be communicated with sufficient notice and supported by operational necessity.

11. Quality Improvement Plan

Continuous improvement activities shall include:

- Staff feedback collection.
- Post-response evaluations.
- Workflow assessments.
- Communication reviews.
- KPI monitoring.

Findings shall be used to improve future outbreak response operations and update SOP documentation.

12. Key Performance Indicators (KPIs)

The following metrics should be monitored:

- Training Completion Rate
- Daily Report Completion Rate
- Data Accuracy Rate
- Communication Response Time
- Staff Satisfaction
- Telework Satisfaction
- Burnout Survey Results
- Overtime Utilization

- Employee Retention During Response Activities

Leadership shall review KPI performance regularly to identify opportunities for improvement.